THE BIG BATTLE FOR SURVIVAL

THE REGIONAL SATRAPS OF MAHARASHTRA, BENGAL AND BIHAR COULD STAND BETWEEN PM MODI AND HIS PLACE IN HISTORY, BUT IF THEY FAIL TO DEFEAT HIM, THEY MIGHT FIND THEMSELVES IN ITS DUSTBIN

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Photo illustration by NILANJAN DAS

A BATTLE OF EPIC PROPORTIONS IS ON IN ELECTION 2024 even as voting for the 543 seats of the Lok Sabha crosses the midway mark on May 7. And it's playing out in three theatres of war—Maharashtra, West Bengal and Bihar. Collectively, they may contribute only a fourth to the total parliamentary strength, but the outcome in these three states will have far-reaching consequences for the nation. It will, for instance, determine whether the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) cruises to a third consecutive majority, or huffs and puffs its way across the finish line. It is also a battle of survival for the regional satraps, who pose a formidable challenge to the dominance the BJP is striving for. They are what stands between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his place in history but, if they fail, they could as easily be consigned to its dustbin.

Like the Mahabharata, the cast of characters waging this do or die battle are a curious motley of political families and parties that have frequently changed sides, affiliations and alignments in their quest for political supremacy in these three states, which together constitute 130 seats. To destroy them, their principal combatant, the BJP, has resorted to every trick in Chanakya's book, be it *saam* (request), *daam* (reward), *dand* (punishment) or *bhed* (creating rifts). So, in Maharashtra, which has 48 seats in the Lok Sabha (second only to Uttar Pradesh, which has 80), patriarch Sharad Pawar is engaged in mortal combat with nephew Ajit Pawar to decide whose faction represents the real Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Their family members, too, have joined the fray, with Ajit's wife Sunetra taking on Pawar's daughter Supriya Sule in their pocket borough Baramati. Guarding another flank is Uddhav Thackeray, his status as heir to the Bal Thackeray